Part III: What the New Covenant Actually Changed

Chapter 13: what is a covenant?

I have to start this Part by admitting how it was built.

This chapter did not exist when I needed it. I wrote three investigations that depended on knowing what a covenant is — what changes in a new one, what sacrifice and priesthood were doing inside one, what circumcision was as a sign of one — before I noticed that I had never defined the word. The definition arrived in the middle of the circumcision work, when an assumption I had been leaning on the whole time finally surfaced far enough to be seen.

The assumption was this: that a covenant and the commandments attached to a covenant were roughly the same thing.

They are not, and almost nothing in this Part works until that is straightened out. So in the book the chapter comes first, where the logic needs it. In the research it came fourth, where I actually noticed.

I am telling you that rather than quietly renumbering, because the gap between those two orders is the honest shape of how this went. A reader who is handed a tidy sequence learns the conclusion. A reader who is told where the author was standing when the floor moved learns the method.

THE WORDS

Hebrew: בְּרִית (*berit*, covenant). Greek, in both the Septuagint and the New Testament: διαθήκη (*diathēkē*).

A working definition, which I will hold loosely enough to be corrected:

> A biblical covenant is a solemn, binding relationship established by commitments or promises, typically involving specified parties, obligations, signs, blessings, consequences, and sometimes an oath or a sacrifice.

TO CUT A COVENANT

כָּרַת בְּרִית · *karat berit* · literally **to cut a covenant**

Scripture does not usually speak of *making* a covenant. It speaks of cutting one. Genesis 15:18 says the LORD made a covenant with Abram, and the verb underneath is *karat* — and the scene immediately before it is animals divided in halves with a smoking fire pot passing between the pieces.

Covenant and sacrifice are joined at the level of vocabulary. That is worth remembering two chapters from now, when the blood of the covenant at Matthew 26:28 arrives.

THE DISTINCTION THE WHOLE PART RESTS ON

Here is the sentence I did not have:

A covenant is not identical to the commandments associated with it.

A covenant can contain obligations, establish them, be sustained by them. The obligations are not the covenant. Once that is separated out, a set of questions becomes available that I had never thought to ask of a text.

Who are the parties. What relationship is being established. What does Yahweh promise. What response is required. Is there a sign. Are there blessings and curses. How long does it endure. What is it doing in the developing story.

Eight questions, and they immediately break sentences I had heard all my life and never inspected. *The Sabbath is the covenant* is one of them. It is not. Scripture says plainly that the Sabbath is a **sign** of a covenant, which is a different claim, and the difference is not pedantry — it changes what evidence would count.

FINDING — FOUR WORDS THAT ARE NOT SYNONYMS

Covenant is the binding relational arrangement. **Promise** is what Yahweh commits to accomplish. **Commandment** is what Yahweh commands. **Covenant sign** is a visible marker associated with a covenant.

They overlap. They are not interchangeable. Treating them as one term is a Category Collapse, and it is the specific collapse underneath most arguments about whether "the Law" is still binding.

Sharpening, because I got this wrong first: every covenant involves promises, but not every promise in Scripture establishes a covenant. Yahweh can promise without cutting a covenant.

THREE SIGNS

Scripture gives three covenant signs explicitly enough that no inference is needed.

The rainbow, to Noah:

> This is the sign of the covenant that I make between me and you and every living creature that is with you, for all future generations (Genesis 9:12)

Circumcision, to Abraham:

> it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and you (Genesis 17:11)

And the Sabbath, to Israel:

> It is a sign forever between me and the people of Israel that in six days the LORD made the heavens and the earth (Exodus 31:17)

Note what Exodus 31:17 grounds it in. Creation, not only Sinai. I am noting that and deliberately setting it aside here; it is a datum for the Sabbath chapter, and using it early would be exactly the kind of move this book keeps refusing.

THE FINDING THIS CHAPTER PRODUCED, WHICH I WAS NOT LOOKING FOR

Then, while laying those three signs side by side, something appeared that neither the circumcision work nor my own notes on the word *olam* had caught.

The same Hebrew phrase is attached to all three.

בְּרִית עוֹלָם (*berit olam*) — usually rendered *everlasting covenant*. It is at Genesis 9:16 of the rainbow. It is at Genesis 17:13 of circumcision. It is at Exodus 31:16 of the Sabbath.

Three institutions. One phrase. And three completely different treatments, in every tradition I know of, including mine.

Nobody argues the rainbow ended. The apostles did not require circumcision of Gentiles. And the Sabbath is contested ground that this book has not yet walked onto.

> ***BERIT OLAM* ON THREE INSTITUTIONS**
>
> That *berit olam* attaches to all three is explicit text.
>
> It **REQUIRES** the conclusion that *olam*, by itself, cannot determine how any one of these institutions functions under later covenantal developments. The phrase is identical; the questions each institution raises are not, and the phrase does not distinguish between them.
>
> I have to be careful about how I state the second half, because it is easy to overreach here and I nearly did. What Acts 15 rejects is imposing circumcision on Gentiles as a requirement for salvation and covenant inclusion. That is **not** the same as Scripture announcing that the Abrahamic *berit olam* has ended, and I do not get to slide from the first to the second because it would tidy the argument.
>
> It does **not** establish that *olam* means "temporary." That would be the opposite error, and it is the one I would have made a year earlier. What it establishes is narrower and more useful: *olam* is not the load-bearing word that arguments on both sides assume it is.

I want to be precise about what that did to my own position, because it cut against me. I had been prepared to lean on *everlasting* when it suited a case and to explain it away when it did not. Finding the phrase distributed across three institutions I treat three ways removed the option of doing either silently.

The lexical study of *olam* is still to be done. This finding does not replace it. It tells me what that study can and cannot be expected to deliver when it comes.

TEXTUAL NOTE — THE TRANSLATIONS ARE NOT CONSISTENT, AND ONE IS

The ESV renders the identical Hebrew phrase as *everlasting covenant* at Genesis 9:16 and 17:13, then as *covenant forever* at Exodus 31:16. The CJB reads *everlasting* at Genesis 17:13 and *perpetual* at Exodus 31:16.

The RVR1960 is the most consistent of the three, reading *pacto perpetuo* in both places.

A reader working from any one of them would find it harder to notice that the three institutions share a phrase — which is precisely how I managed not to notice it for a very long time.

THE COVENANTS ACCUMULATE, BUT "ADDENDUM" IS THE WRONG WORD

The instinct I brought to this was that the covenants stack. Yahweh promises, then later develops the arrangement, and the story accumulates rather than Yahweh discarding everything prior each time.

There is something genuinely biblical in that instinct, and it needs one correction. *Addendum* implies each covenant adds terms to a single unchanged contract. What Scripture gives is richer than that.

Noah's covenant is not a failed first attempt, and it does not vanish when Abraham arrives. Sinai is not Abraham version two; it is connected to Abraham and distinct from it. David does not erase Abraham. The story becomes more specific as

it goes, concentrating toward Messiah rather than being replaced at each step.

> **COVENANT AS AN ANCIENT NEAR EASTERN FORM**
>
> Covenant, in the ancient Near East, was a recognizable legal and political form, used between kings and between a king and a subject people. Its elements — named parties, stipulations, witnesses, blessings for loyalty, curses for betrayal, a ratifying ceremony — appear across the region's treaty documents. Israel's Scriptures use that recognizable shape and put Yahweh in it. Recognizing the form is not reducing revelation to politics; it is noticing the vocabulary the first hearers already had.

AND THEN JEREMIAH, WHO DOES NOT FIT THE ACCUMULATION MODEL

Jeremiah 31 announces a **new** covenant with Israel and Judah, and says explicitly that it is *not like* the covenant made with their fathers, the covenant *that they broke*.

That is not accumulation. A covenant has genuinely been broken, and the text says so without softening it.

But notice what Yahweh does not say. There is no sentence anywhere in the passage announcing that everything previously promised is canceled. What the passage actually says next is that the Torah goes inside: *I will put my Torah within them, and I will write it on their hearts.*

So both things stand at once. The parties are the same — Yahweh, Israel, Judah. Yahweh still calls what He writes within them **my Torah**, תּוֹרָתִי (*torati*), which is explicit. The relationship formula is the same: *I will be their God, and they shall be my people*. And against that, it is genuinely new, genuinely unlike the Exodus covenant, and it deals with a covenant that was genuinely broken.

What the passage does **not** do is enumerate how each command functions under the new covenant. It names the Torah as His and relocates it; it does not tell me that every element of the Mosaic legislation continues in precisely the same covenantal form. Saying it did would be the Category Collapse I am about to spend five chapters refusing.

> **FINDING — NEITHER HALF MAY SWALLOW THE OTHER**
>
> Every reading I had met before resolved Jeremiah 31 by eliminating one of its two halves. Either the continuity is emphasized until *new* means nothing, or the discontinuity is emphasized until *Israel*, *Judah* and *Torah* in the same sentence mean nothing.
>
> The passage holds both. A reading that needs one half to disappear is telling me about itself, not about Jeremiah.

That is the correction this chapter makes to my own earlier language. I had been saying *one covenant story*. That is too flat. What Scripture gives is one covenantal story containing multiple covenants, culminating in Messiah — which avoids

the two opposite errors of pretending nothing ever changed and pretending the story changed owners.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. Covenant, commandment, promise and sign are four things, not one, and separating them is what makes the rest of this Part possible. *Berit olam* sits on the rainbow, on circumcision and on the Sabbath, which are treated three different ways — so the phrase cannot settle any of them, and *olam* is not the decisive word either side assumes. The covenants accumulate without being addenda to one contract, and Jeremiah 31 is genuinely new and genuinely continuous at the same time, with neither half permitted to swallow the other.

> **THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES.** The tools exist now. So the question that started this Part can finally be asked in a form that can be answered: when Scripture says a new covenant came, what specifically does it say changed?

Chapter 14: what actually changes in the new covenant

Now that covenant, commandment, promise and sign are four words instead of one, the question can be asked properly.

Jeremiah 31 is where almost everyone starts, including me, and it is worth reading slowly because the passage says several things at once and most arguments I have heard keep only one of them.

THE RECIPIENTS DO NOT CHANGE

> Behold, the days are coming, declares the LORD, when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and the house of Judah (Jeremiah 31:31)

That is the first thing, and it is the thing I had never really absorbed. The new covenant is announced to Israel and Judah. Not to a different people, not to a replacement, not to an unnamed general audience. Whatever else is new about it, the parties named are the parties who were already there.

I am not going to build a conclusion on that yet. Part IV is where the question of who else is brought in gets its own treatment, and settling it from one verse here would be ex-

actly the shortcut this book keeps refusing. But the verse has to be read before it can be built on, and read plainly it does not announce a change of recipient.

"NOT LIKE THE COVENANT I MADE WITH THEIR FATHERS"

Then the contrast, stated by Yahweh rather than inferred:

> not like the covenant that I made with their fathers … my covenant that they broke (Jeremiah 31:32)

This is where my own earlier language had to be corrected. I had been saying *one covenant story*, and that is too flat — it smooths over a text that says a covenant was broken and that what comes next is *not like* it.

The refinement that survives is this: **one covenantal story containing multiple covenants, culminating in Messiah.** It avoids pretending nothing ever changed, and it avoids pretending the story changed owners.

TORAH INTERNALIZED, AND THE BRAKE THAT GOES WITH IT

> I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts. And I will be their God, and they shall be my people (Jeremiah 31:33)

JEREMIAH 31:33 — WHERE THE TORAH GOES

נָתַתִּי אֶת־תּוֹרָתִי בְּקִרְבָּם · *natatti et-torati beqirbam* · "I will put my Torah **within them**"

וְעַל־לִבָּם אֶכְתֲּבֶנָּה · *ve'al-libam ekhtavennah* · "and **upon their heart** I will write it"

What is **not** happening: Torah discarded. What **is** happening: the location changes. External and on stone becomes internal and on the heart.

The CJB reads "my Torah" outright. The RVR1960 splits the location across two faculties — *en su mente y en su corazón*, in their mind and on their heart — where the ESV and CJB both keep it to "within them / on their hearts."

And immediately, before that sentence can be used for anything, the brake.

Jeremiah does not here give a verse-by-verse account of how each Mosaic command functions under the new covenant. He does not mention the Sabbath, circumcision, sacrifice, food or the festivals. So:

FINDING — THE SLOGAN THAT MUST NOT BE ALLOWED TO PRE-ANSWER THIS PART

"Torah written on the heart" cannot be used to settle Sabbath, circumcision, sacrifice, dietary law and festivals without investigating each one. Doing that would be a Category Collapse wearing a Jeremiah quotation as cover.

It is the exact move I would have made, and the next five chapters exist because I did not get to make it.

THE VERSE I WOULD RATHER NOT HAVE READ CAREFULLY

> And no longer shall each one teach his neighbor … for they shall all know me, from the least of them to the greatest (Jeremiah 31:34)

Hebrews 8 quotes this approvingly as describing the covenant being inaugurated. And whatever else is claimed about that inauguration, this clause is not obviously descriptive of any community I can observe, then or now. Teaching plainly continued in the apostolic congregations. Hebrews itself is a teaching document, which makes the tension internal to the very argument quoting it.

OPEN QUESTION — A COST FOR ANY FULLY-ARRIVED READING

Possible readings: an eschatological not-yet; a claim about covenant membership rather than pedagogy, meaning all who are *within* it know Him, unlike Israel where membership was ethnic; or hyperbolic covenant language of a recognized kind.

Not adjudicated. I am recording it because it is a genuine cost for any reading — including the one I am moving toward — that treats the new covenant as fully consummated.

TEXTUAL NOTE — THE CJB IS ONE VERSE BEHIND HERE

A direct lookup of "Jeremiah 31:33" in the CJB returns the text the ESV numbers as 31:34. The offset in this range is exactly one verse.

Anyone checking a CJB citation of Jeremiah 31 against this chapter should check the wording, never the number alone.

EZEKIEL 36, WHICH COMPLICATES A MODEL I HAD BEEN CARRYING

Jeremiah does not stand alone. Ezekiel says the same thing from the other side.

> And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you … And I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes and be careful to obey my rules (Ezekiel 36:26-27)

Read the sequence: new heart, new spirit, Yahweh's Spirit within, and then obedience.

That order complicates any model in which the Spirit *replaces* obedience. Ezekiel presents the Ruach as the power by which covenant faithfulness happens, and all three translations agree on the causal construction — *cause you to walk*, *haré que andéis*.

This was an addition to my own framework rather than a confirmation of it. I had been describing the Spirit as illuminating and guiding. Ezekiel adds a third function I had not

had: producing covenant faithfulness. It arrived from the prophets rather than from anything my epistemology needed.

EZEKIEL 37, WHERE THE TEXT SUPPLIES ITS OWN KEY

The new-heart promise is followed immediately by the valley of dry bones, and then Yahweh interprets His own vision rather than leaving it to me:

> Son of man, these bones are the whole house of Israel (Ezekiel 37:11)

Resurrection imagery, applied by the text itself to the restoration of Israel. That is not an interpreter's allegory; it is the same move Revelation 1:20 makes when it says the seven stars are the angels of the seven assemblies. Where a text supplies its own decoding, the decoding outranks my guesses.

And then the detail that cuts against a simple *Torah discarded* reading, which I had been half-holding without examining:

Ezekiel 37:24 places *they shall walk in my rules and be careful to obey my statutes* **inside** the everlasting-covenant promise, alongside the one king. Torah-keeping is not presented there as the thing being left behind. It is presented as a feature of the restored state.

> **EZEKIEL 37:24 — TORAH-KEEPING INSIDE THE EVERLASTING COVENANT**
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> Ezekiel 37:24's placement of Torah-keeping inside the everlasting covenant is explicit text, and it [SUPPORTS] the internalized-not-erased reading of Jeremiah 31:33 from an independent prophet.
>
> It does **not** establish how any specific command functions afterward. It establishes the category, not the contents.

AND THE PART OF EZEKIEL 37 THAT IS A PROBLEM FOR ME

I have to print this rather than move past it.

> I will set my sanctuary in their midst forevermore (Ezekiel 37:26-28, twice)

That promise sits inside the same everlasting-covenant passage supplying the one-king and Torah-keeping material I have just used. I do not get to harvest a passage for the parts that help and skip the part that does not.

A framework that reads temple language as passing away in the first century owes an account of this. So does any reading that treats the new covenant as fully arrived without a sanctuary.

OPEN QUESTION — FOUR LIVE OPTIONS, NONE SELECTED

(a) Fulfilled in Messiah, or in a Spirit-indwelt people as the sanctuary — 2 Corinthians 6:16 appears to quote Ezekiel 37:27, a citation this chapter does not lean on. (b) Fulfilled partially and conditionally in the Second Temple period. (c) Still future. (d) Governed by Ezekiel 40 through 48's temple vision, which needs its own investigation.

Ezekiel 40 to 48 is set aside and deliberately not opened here. Opening it mid-chapter would mean deciding a large question inside a small one.

So Jeremiah 31, Ezekiel 36 and Ezekiel 37 belong together — and together they are harder to systematize than any one of them alone. That is the honest report, and I would rather leave it that way than produce a tidier chapter.

THE VEIL, WITH THE SEAM LEFT VISIBLE

> And behold, the curtain of the temple was torn in two, from top to bottom (Matthew 27:51)

That is the observation, and the direction is not incidental; it reads as an act from above rather than below.

But Matthew does not interpret it. He reports it. The theological weight that this event opened access comes from Hebrews 10:19 to 22, which speaks of confidence to enter by the blood of Yeshua through a new and living way opened through the curtain.

I am keeping that seam visible on purpose. This book is not inventing symbolism around Matthew's sentence; an apostolic writer develops the relationship, and the difference between *the text says* and *an apostle concludes* is one this book does not get to blur just because both land where I want.

WHICH CHANGES THE PRIESTHOOD QUESTION

Under the Levitical arrangement the priests enter the Holy Place and the High Priest alone enters the Holy of Holies, under prescribed conditions. Hebrews presents something structurally different:

> we have a great high priest who has passed through the heavens, Jesus, the Son of God (Hebrews 4:14)

Developed through Psalm 110:4 and its priest forever after the order of Melchizedek.

The structural point is the one I had missed for years. Israel's ordinary arrangement keeps the offices in **different tribes**: Davidic kingship in Judah, Aaronic priesthood in Levi. That separation is structural, not administrative detail. A figure uniting kingship and everlasting priesthood is not a small adjustment to the Levitical system — it is something that system could not produce from inside itself by its own tribal logic. Which is exactly the argument Hebrews 7:11 and 12 makes.

EVIDENCE I WANTED, AND DO NOT GET TO USE

Zechariah 6:12 and 13 look, at first reading, like the prophets already working this ground: the man whose name is the Branch, who builds the temple of the LORD, bears royal honor, sits and rules on his throne — and a priest.

I would like to use that. I am not going to.

> **ZECHARIAH 6:13 — CONTRARY EVIDENCE, PRINTED**
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> The translations split on the decisive clause. The ESV reads "there shall be **a priest on his throne**," which plausibly makes it the same figure. The CJB reads "a *cohen* **before his throne**." The RVR1960 reads "habrá sacerdote **a su lado**," at his side. Two of the three read the priest as a **separate** figure.
>
> And all three end with the counsel of peace being *between them both*, which reads more naturally of two parties than of one.
>
> So Zechariah 6:13 is **weaker support** for "Messiah unites both offices" than it first appears, and this chapter does not lean on it. The priest-king case rests on Psalm 110:4 and Hebrews 7, which are explicit. Zechariah is recorded as **suggestive, not load-bearing**.

That is the same discipline this book applied to the CJB's "this people" at Matthew 24:34, and it has to run in both directions or it is not a discipline. When the translations split on a clause I would like to use, the split gets printed rather than buried.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. The new covenant is announced to Israel and Judah, and the recipients do not change. Torah is relocated rather than discarded — and that sentence is not allowed to pre-answer a single specific command. Ezekiel adds that the Spirit produces covenant faithfulness rather than replacing it, and places Torah-keeping inside the everlasting covenant. Two costs are on the record against my own developing position: Jeremiah 31:34's universal knowing, and Ezekiel's sanctuary forevermore. The priest-king case stands on Psalm 110 and Hebrews 7, and explicitly not on Zechariah 6.

> **THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES.** If Torah is internalized rather than erased, then the institutions have to be taken one at a time rather than as a bloc. The first and hardest is the one the whole system was built around: sacrifice, and the priesthood that carried it.

Chapter 15: sacrifice, priesthood, and what fulfilment looks like

This is the chapter where I had to define a word I had been using for years without defining: *fulfilled*.

And I decided to do it the slow way. Not by opening Hebrews, which is where every argument I had ever had about this begins, but by reading Leviticus first — so that whatever Hebrews says would be landing on something I had already looked at, rather than supplying both the question and the answer.

SACRIFICE HAD A REAL FUNCTION, AND THE MEDIATOR WAS HIMSELF LIMITED

The first thing reading Leviticus does is remove a caricature I had absorbed without noticing: that the sacrificial system was a placeholder, a sort of divine waiting room, tolerated rather than given.

It is given. It has a stated covenantal function. And the High Priest who administers it is himself under it — he offers for his own sin before he offers for the people's. Whatever the system is, it is not a system in which one man stands outside the problem.

TWO GOATS, AND TWO MOVEMENTS

Hebrews later concentrates on blood and on access to the sanctuary. Leviticus 16 gives something richer than that, and reading it first is what makes the difference visible.

> And Aaron shall cast lots over the two goats, one lot for the LORD and the other lot for Azazel (Leviticus 16:8)

One goat is killed and its blood is brought inside the veil. The other is presented alive, has the iniquities of the people confessed over it with both of Aaron's hands laid on its head, and is then sent away:

> The goat shall bear all their iniquities on itself to a remote area (Leviticus 16:22)

So there are two distinct movements, not one. Sin is **atoned for**, and sin is **carried away**. The ritual structure says both, explicitly, and the second is not a poetic restatement of the first.

I am recording that before opening Hebrews, on purpose. When the New Testament speaks of Yeshua bearing sins and of taking away sin, I want that observation already on the table rather than retrofitted to fit.

TEXTUAL NOTE — THE TRANSLATIONS DECLINE THE FAMILIAR GLOSS

Popular English memory says *scapegoat*, which is the KJV's rendering and the origin of the English word. All three of the witnesses I work from decline it and transliterate a name instead: ESV *Azazel*, CJB *'Az'azel*, RVR1960 *Azazel*.

That cuts a specific way, and only that way. It does **not** establish a personal referent — transliteration is also what translators do when a word's meaning is genuinely uncertain. It does establish that "it obviously just means scapegoat" is not the settled position it is usually assumed to be.

Candidate meanings remain: the goat itself, "the goat that departs"; removal or sending away; a wilderness location; or a personal referent. Not resolved here.

ISAIAH 53, AND EVIDENCE THAT IS WEAKER THAN I WANTED

By Isaiah, sacrificial vocabulary has concentrated onto a person. I would like Isaiah 53:10 to say plainly that the servant *is* a guilt offering. Two of my three translations read it that way. One does not.

> **ISAIAH 53:10 — CONTRARY EVIDENCE, PRINTED**
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> The ESV reads "**when** his soul makes an offering for guilt." The RVR1960 reads "**cuando** haya puesto su vida en expiación por el pecado." The CJB introduces a conditional: "to see **if** he would present himself as a guilt offering. **If he does**…"
>
> That is a different construal of the Hebrew, not a stylistic preference. אָשָׁם (*asham*), guilt offering, is present in all three. What is contested is whether Isaiah **asserts** that the servant becomes one or **poses it conditionally**.
>
> Even under the weaker reading the finding survives, and it is worth stating at the strength it actually has: Isaiah has already put person, sin-bearing and guilt-offering vocabulary together. The New Testament did not look at Yeshua after the fact and invent sacrificial symbolism. The categories were converging on a person before anyone had to explain a crucifixion.

YESHUA INTERPRETS HIS OWN DEATH COVENANTALLY — AND ONE WORD I CANNOT USE

At the table, Yeshua says the cup is His blood of the covenant. That framing is His own; nobody supplied it afterward.

TEXTUAL NOTE — DO NOT LEAN ON MATTHEW FOR THE WORD "NEW"

The ESV at Matthew 26:28 reads "my blood of the covenant." The RVR1960 reads "mi sangre del **nuevo** pacto." The CJB reads "ratifies the **New** Covenant."

The presence of *new*, καινῆς (*kainēs*), at Matthew 26:28 is text-critically contested: it is in the Byzantine and majority tradition the RVR1960 follows and absent from the critical text the ESV follows.

So the claim "Yeshua Himself called it the new covenant" should rest on **Luke 22:20 and 1 Corinthians 11:25**, where the word is secure — not on Matthew 26:28. The covenantal framing of Matthew is secure. The specific adjective is not. I am flagging this as a manuscript question rather than resolving it; full apparatus work is beyond what I have done.

That is a small correction and it cost me nothing, which is exactly why it is worth making. A claim I can support from two secure verses does not need a third contested one, and reaching for the contested one anyway is how arguments quietly become unreliable.

SHADOW, AND THE DEFINITION THIS BOOK RUNS ON

Only now does Hebrews enter.

> For since the law has but a shadow of the good things to come instead of the true form of these realities (Hebrews 10:1)

> See that you make everything according to the pattern that was shown you on the mountain (Hebrews 8:5)

A shadow is not a lie. A shadow is produced by something real, and it tells you something true about that reality while not being the reality in its fullness.

> **FINDING — WHAT FULFILMENT MEANS IN THIS BOOK**
>
> **Pattern reaching its reality.** Not falsehood replaced by truth.
>
> So: fulfilment can mean that an earlier God-given institution reaches its intended goal in Messiah, such that continuing the earlier form *as though the fulfilment had not occurred* would misunderstand the institution's own purpose.
>
> Read what that does not say. It does not say the earlier form was false. It does not say its continuation is impossible. It says it would misunderstand its own purpose. That distinction is load-bearing, and I will need it intact three chapters from now when a far more contested institution arrives.

This is the most useful thing this chapter produced, and it is useful precisely because it refuses both of the positions I had been offered my whole life. It does not insult the Torah, and it does not freeze it.

REPETITION, AND A MAN WHO SITS DOWN

Hebrews' argument about repetition is sharper than the summary version I had been carrying. The point is not that repeated sacrifice was ineffective. It is that repetition demonstrates something about completion — a thing finished does not need doing again.

And then the detail I had read past many times, which Hebrews makes itself and does not need my help with. Every priest **stands daily** at his service, offering repeatedly the same sacrifices. Messiah, having offered one sacrifice for sins, **sat down**.

That is an argument made out of posture, and it is better than most arguments made out of adjectives.

THE PRIESTHOOD CHANGES FOR THE SAME REASON

Which brings back the structural point from the last chapter, now with its cause attached. The offices were separated by tribe: kingship in Judah, priesthood in Levi. A priest-king cannot be produced from inside that arrangement. So Hebrews reaches past Levi to Melchizedek and to Psalm 110:4 — a priest forever, of an order that predates Aaron and does not depend on descent from him.

The change in priesthood is not an administrative reshuffle. It is the thing that requires a change in the arrangement itself, which is what Hebrews 7 argues in as many words.

FULFILMENT IS NOT PERMISSION TO INVENT PARALLELS

One warning, and I am putting it in the body of the chapter because I have watched this go wrong, including in my own notes.

Having found a real pattern-to-reality relationship that Scripture itself draws, the temptation is to start drawing others. Every piece of tabernacle furniture becomes a cipher; every festival detail becomes a prediction; the whole system turns into a code that the sufficiently clever reader can decrypt.

Hebrews does not do that. It develops a small number of correspondences and argues them. Where Scripture draws the line, I follow it. Where it does not, my ingenuity is not evidence.

OPEN QUESTION — DOES "ONCE FOR ALL" MEAN HE STOPPED BEING PRIEST?

Hebrews says the offering was made once for all, and Hebrews also presents Him as continuing to intercede. Those are not obviously the same tense.

I am not resolving it here. Psalm 110 holds both offices in one psalm and does not tell me how they run concurrently. Recording it rather than choosing the reading that tidies the chapter.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. Leviticus gives two movements, atonement and removal, and the New Testament's sin-bearing language lands on both. Isaiah had already concentrated sacrificial vocabulary onto a person, though less securely than I wanted. Fulfilment is defined here as pattern reaching its reality, not falsehood giving way to truth — which neither insults the Torah nor freezes it. The priesthood changes because a priest-king could not be produced from within a tribally separated system. And "new" at Matthew 26:28 is contested, so the claim rests on Luke and Paul instead.

THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES. Sacrifice was the institution the whole system was built around, and it has a defensible account. The next one is smaller, older than Sinai, and it is where the apostles themselves had their sharpest recorded fight.

Chapter 16: circumcision — covenant sign, heart, and Messiah

The second test case is smaller than sacrifice, older than Sinai, and it is where the apostles had their sharpest recorded disagreement. Which makes it a better test than sacrifice in one specific way: I cannot settle it by quoting Hebrews, because the people who lived through it did not settle it that way either.

START WHERE SCRIPTURE STARTS

Circumcision is given to Abraham, not at Sinai. That matters more than I had realized, because it means the sign predates the covenant most arguments assume it belongs to.

Genesis gives it as a covenant sign, gives its scope — Abraham's household, including those not descended from him — and attaches a serious consequence for neglecting it. This is not a peripheral rite.

And then Genesis does something to the sequence that Paul will later build an argument on.

DECLARED RIGHTEOUS BEFORE THE SIGN

Genesis 15:6 has Abraham believing Yahweh, and it being counted to him as righteousness. Genesis 17 gives circumcision.

The order is not decorative, and Paul says so directly in Romans 4: Abraham received the sign of circumcision as a seal of a righteousness he had **already** had by faith while still uncircumcised. Which makes him, in Paul's argument, father of both the circumcised and the uncircumcised who walk in that faith.

I want to be careful here, because this is a place where I could overreach. The sequence establishes that the righteousness preceded the sign. It does not by itself establish what the sign is for afterward.

DEUTERONOMY MOVES IT INWARD — TWICE, AND DIFFERENTLY

Then something I had not noticed until I read the two passages together.

Deuteronomy 10:16 takes the physical sign and turns it into an internal command: *circumcise therefore the foreskin of your heart*. That is an imperative addressed to Israel.

And then Deuteronomy 30:6 says Yahweh Himself will do it: *the LORD your God will circumcise your heart*.

Command, then promise. The same image used first as an obligation and then as something Yahweh undertakes to accomplish. Jeremiah later sharpens it into an indictment, saying the house of Israel is uncircumcised in heart — which only works as a rebuke if the inward sense was already established and expected.

> **CIRCUMCISION MOVED INWARD, INSIDE THE TANAKH**
>
> That Scripture itself moves circumcision inward, before any apostle writes, is explicit text at Deuteronomy 10:16, Deuteronomy 30:6 and Jeremiah 9.
>
> It [SUPPORTS] reading the New Testament's heart-circumcision language as continuous with Israel's own prophetic vocabulary rather than as a novel reinterpretation.
>
> It does **not** establish that the physical sign thereby ceases. Deuteronomy holds both at once and does not treat the inward meaning as cancelling the outward one.

ACTS 15, AND GETTING THE PROPOSITION EXACTLY RIGHT

This is where the apostolic disagreement happens, and the first thing to do is state precisely what was being disputed — because the whole chapter collapses into noise if the proposition is fuzzy.

The question was **not** whether circumcision is good, or whether Jewish believers should stop. It was whether Gentiles must be circumcised and keep the law of Moses **in or-**

der to be saved. That is a claim about a condition of entry, and it is the claim the council rejects.

Peter answers from experience rather than from theory: Yahweh gave the Spirit to Gentiles, cleansing their **hearts** by faith. The hearts language is not accidental — it is the Deuteronomy and Jeremiah vocabulary arriving in an apostolic argument, which is what happens when you read in sequence rather than by topic.

James then appeals to the prophets, which is the same one-covenantal-story move Chapter 13 arrived at from a different direction.

THE CONTROL CASE THAT SETTLES IT

Here is the strongest argument in the chapter, and it comes from narrative rather than from anyone's theological assertion.

Paul circumcised Timothy. Acts 16:3 says he did it because of the Jews in those places, who all knew Timothy's father was Greek.

Paul refused to allow Titus to be circumcised. Galatians 2:3 to 5 says that because false brothers had come in to spy out their freedom, he did not yield for a moment, so that the truth of the good news might be preserved.

Same man. Same practice. Opposite decisions.

> **FINDING — THE TWO EPISODES ARE ONLY CONTRADICTORY IF CIRCUMCISION ITSELF IS THE ISSUE**
>
> Paul is not against circumcision. He is against circumcision **as a condition of Gentile justification and covenant inclusion in Messiah**.
>
> Once that is the proposition, Timothy and Titus are perfectly coherent: one was a contextual missionary decision, the other a demand carrying a theological claim Paul judged to be a different gospel. The difference is not in the act. It is in what the act was being made to signify.
>
> This is the kind of finding that only appears if narratives are read alongside theological statements instead of being treated as illustration.

ROMANS 2, AND A CAUTION THAT CUTS AGAINST ME

Romans 2:28 and 29 say the real Jew is one inwardly, and circumcision is of the heart, by the Spirit.

I would like to use that verse more heavily than I am going to.

FINDING — ROMANS 2 MUST NOT BE MADE LOAD-BEARING

Paul is not necessarily saying that ethnic Jews cease being Jews, or that Gentile believers become ethnic Jews. The immediate argument concerns covenant faithfulness and judgment: outward identity without inward faithfulness shields nobody.

Using Romans 2 as a shortcut to erase ethnic Israel, while claiming to oppose replacement theology, would **reproduce the same error in reverse**. This framework has already had to discipline its own preferred vocabulary once for exactly this reason, and the correction does not get to be forgotten because it is now inconvenient in the other direction.

The stronger and safer case for Gentile incorporation is Romans 11's grafting, Ephesians 2's brought-near and fellow-citizens language, and Galatians 3's Abrahamic inheritance. Romans 2 is not the load-bearing text and should not be made one.

THE VERSE THAT GUARDS THE WHOLE ARGUMENT

> Was anyone … uncircumcised? Let him not seek circumcision. For neither circumcision counts for anything nor uncircumcision, but keeping the commandments of God (1 Corinthians 7:18-19)

Paul puts both halves in a single sentence, and the sentence is the guardrail. It prevents *physical circumcision is not required* from sliding into *obedience does not matter*.

WHAT PAUL MEANS BY "THE COMMANDMENTS OF GOD"

What does Paul mean by "the commandments of God" if physical circumcision was itself commanded by God?

I do not know, and the reason is specific: Paul never defines the phrase in this context. Resolving it means gathering his usage across the letters, which is its own investigation and not this one.

Recorded as unfinished rather than papered over with a plausible guess.

GALATIANS 3 TAKES IT BACK BEFORE SINAI

Paul's argument in Galatians 3 is chronological, and it is the same instinct this Part has been running on: the promise to Abraham came first, and a covenant arriving four hundred and thirty years later does not annul a prior promise.

That is not a claim that Sinai was a mistake. It is a claim about order of operations, and it is the same structure Chapter 13 found in the accumulating covenants.

AND NOW THE PROBLEM THAT CIRCUMCISION CREATES

Genesis calls circumcision בְּרִית עוֹלָם (*berit olam*) — the same phrase Chapter 13 found on the rainbow and on the Sabbath.

And its covenantal function plainly looks transformed in Messiah.

So the pressure is obvious, and so is the shortcut.

> **FINDING — THE BRAKE, STATED AS A RULE BECAUSE THIS IS THE MOST TEMPTING SHORTCUT AVAILABLE**
>
> Do **not** resolve *olam* opportunistically because circumcision created a difficulty.
>
> A convenient reading of *olam* would relieve several pressures at once, including Ezekiel 37's everlasting covenant and its sanctuary from two chapters ago. **That convenience is precisely the reason to hold it.** A word study conducted in order to relieve a pressure is not a word study; it is advocacy with a lexicon.
>
> The question is real and remains open: is *olam* invariably endless and incapable of transformation, or is it perpetual, age-lasting, enduring throughout an appointed order? It cannot be answered from the English word *everlasting*, and it is worth noting that the RVR1960 already reads *perpetuo*, which leans the second way. Three translations, two framings, before any analysis has started.
>
> The stakes are much larger than circumcision: *olam* attaches to priestly statutes, festivals, covenant promises, the land, and to Yahweh Himself. It gets its own study, later, on its own terms.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. Circumcision predates Sinai, but the righteousness it seals precedes it. Scripture moves it inward on its own, as command and then as promise, long before an apostle does. Acts 15 rejects a specific proposition — circumcision as a condition of Gentile salvation — and not the practice itself, which is why Paul can circumcise Timothy and refuse it for Titus without contradiction. Romans 2 is deliberately not made to carry more than it says. And the *olam* problem is now sitting on two institutions instead of one, with the brake held rather than released.

> **THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES.** Two test cases in, the method is holding: each institution is being asked its own question rather than answered by a slogan. The third is the one where I was most confident going in, and where a single participle is about to make me much less confident.

Chapter 17: clean and unclean, from Noah to Messiah

This is the chapter where I was most confident going in, and where I finish with less than I started.

I knew the answer to this one. Peter's sheet, Mark 7, all foods declared clean, done. I had said it in conversations for years with the particular ease of a man who has never checked.

THE DISTINCTION PREDATES ISRAEL

The first problem for my tidy answer is that clean and unclean are not Levitical inventions. Noah is told to take the clean animals by sevens and the unclean by twos, generations before Sinai, and Genesis offers no explanation because it evidently expects none to be needed.

And the first explicit function of the distinction is not diet. It is sacrifice. Noah takes extra clean animals and the next thing he does with them is offer them.

GENESIS 9:3, WHICH IS A REAL DIFFICULTY FOR THE OTHER SIDE

Then, immediately after the flood, Yahweh tells Noah that every moving thing that lives shall be food for him, as he had given the green plants.

I am putting that on the table rather than in a footnote, because it is a genuine difficulty for a straightforward everything-in-Leviticus-is-permanent reading, and I have watched people who hold my general instincts skip past it.

OPEN QUESTION — THE FIRST GENUINE ONE IN THIS CHAPTER

How does Genesis 9:3's grant relate to a clean/unclean distinction the same book has already assumed and that Leviticus later legislates in detail?

I do not have a resolution I would defend. The options — that 9:3 concerns permission to eat flesh at all rather than species; that it is a general statement later specified; that the categories are doing different work in the two passages — are all available and none is established by the text in front of me.

LEVITICUS SAYS "UNCLEAN TO YOU," AND SAYS WHY

Leviticus 11 legislates the distinction in detail, and two features of it are easy to read past.

The first is the recurring phrase *unclean* ***to you***. That is jurisdictional language. It says who the legislation addresses, which is a question rather than an assumption.

The second is that Leviticus supplies its own rationale, and the rationale is theological rather than medical: be holy, for I am holy. I had absorbed a folk explanation about shellfish and trichinosis somewhere in childhood. Leviticus does not give that explanation. It gives a different one, and it gives it plainly.

MARK 7, AND IDENTIFYING THE ACTUAL DISPUTE

Now the passage I had been leaning on.

The first thing to do is name what is actually being argued about in Mark 7, because it is not what I assumed. The dispute is about **hand washing** — a tradition of the elders — not about species of animal. Yeshua's charge is that they have set aside the commandment of God to hold their tradition, and He makes it with an example about *korban* and honoring parents.

Then the parenthesis everything hangs on.

TEXTUAL NOTE — MARK 7:19 HAS NO STATED SUBJECT, AND ONE WITNESS KEEPS IT THAT WAY

The Greek is καθαρίζων πάντα τὰ βρώματα (*katharizōn panta ta brōmata*), something like *cleansing all the foods*. **καθαρίζων (*katharizōn*) is a participle. The Greek contains no explicit "he declared."**

- **ESV:** "(Thus **he declared** all foods clean.)" — supplies a subject and a declarative verb
- **NIV:** "(In saying this, **Jesus declared** all foods clean.)" — supplies the subject by name
- **CJB:** "(Thus he declared all foods **ritually** clean.)" — supplies the subject *and* narrows the scope with an added adverb
- **RVR1960:** "Esto decía, **haciendo limpios** todos los alimentos." — **keeps the participial construction** (*haciendo limpios*) rather than converting it to a declarative *declaró limpios*. It is not, however, a grammatically neutral reproduction of the Greek: *Esto decía* makes an interpretive relation explicit, and Spanish is pro-drop, so a clause carries an understood subject without any overt pronoun. RVR1960 is **less interpretively resolved** than the others. It does not thereby settle the syntax.

Two separate interpretive moves are visible, and each is an addition to the Greek. The first is supplying *he declared*, which is not in the sentence.

I want to state what that does and does not show, because I overstated it at first. The older alternative reading — that the digestive process is what cleanses — is a real interpretive possibility with a long history. But it is not established merely by noticing that Greek lacks the English words *he declared*. Greek participles routinely carry an understood syntactic referent, and the absence of an explicitly repeated noun or pronoun does not by itself make two readings equally available. Deciding between them requires syntax and discourse analysis I have not done.

So what I can record is this: the parenthesis is an interpretive act in every English Bible on my desk, the alternative reading is genuinely

old and genuinely possible, and one of my witnesses preserves the participial form rather than resolving it.

The second is the CJB's *ritually*, which narrows the claim substantially: from *all foods are clean* to *all foods are ritually clean*, bearing on the hand-washing dispute rather than on species.

And the interest runs both ways, which is worth saying plainly. The CJB is a Messianic Jewish translation with a stake in the narrower reading. The ESV and NIV are traditional Christian translations with a stake in the broader one. Neither observation settles the grammar. What it means is that the parenthesis in every English Bible here is an interpretive act, and the reader is generally not told so.

And a second question survives even if the declarative reading is right: what does Mark mean by *foods*, βρώματα (*brōmata*)? Every biological creature is now food, or everything already classified as food cannot morally defile a person through ritual hand contamination? Those are not the same claim, and settling the grammar would not settle the referent.

PETER, WHO WOULD NOT LET ME USE THE EASY ANSWER

Then Acts 10, the other half of my confident answer.

The sheet comes down, the voice says kill and eat, Peter refuses, and the voice says what God has made clean do not call common. Peter does not understand it — Luke says he was perplexed as to what the vision might mean, which is already a problem for anyone quoting it as self-evident.

And then Luke does something that took the argument out of my hands: he lets Peter interpret his own vision.

> God has shown me that I should not call any **person** common or unclean (Acts 10:28)

Peter does not say God showed him that pigs are clean. He says he must not call any human being common or unclean. And when he opens his mouth in Cornelius' house, what comes out is that God shows no partiality, and that in every nation anyone who fears Him and does what is right is acceptable to Him.

> **PETER'S VISION — WHAT LUKE MAKES EXPLICIT**
>
> That the primary narrative purpose of Peter's vision is Gentile inclusion is **established** at very high confidence, and not by my preference — Luke puts Peter's own interpretation inside the narrative.

FINDING — THE BRAKE, APPLIED IN THE DIRECTION THAT COSTS ME

Do **not** move from *the vision's primary meaning concerns people* to *therefore the vision has no implications whatsoever for food*. That is the Anti-Replacement Principle: showing interpretation A insufficient does not establish B.

The vision deliberately uses food categories. The command really is *kill and eat*. The voice really does say *what God cleansed, do not call common*.

So a legitimate question survives: does Yahweh use dietary imagery merely as an analogy Peter would grasp immediately, or does the vision simultaneously reflect some transformed status of the distinctions themselves? Acts 10 makes the human meaning explicit. Any dietary implication requires additional evidence. That is the precise position — neither more nor less.

Daniel's table, and two things I had remembered wrong

This comes before Romans 14 rather than after, because Daniel is not a cross-reference here. He is the earlier biblical precedent for exactly the kind of food problem Romans 14 presents, and meeting Paul's weak-conscience believer with no scriptural category for him would have been reading in the wrong order.

Two corrections to what I thought I knew, both recorded because the corrected version is better than the remembered one.

I had it that Daniel was told in a vision, or by an angel, not to eat the king's food. He was not. The text says Daniel *resolved* — he acts on an already-formed conviction, with no command reported. The visions come **afterward**, at 1:17, as a gift.

> And I had it that the other youths grew weaker. They do not. The text says Daniel and his companions were better in appearance and fatter in flesh. It is a comparative statement about the four, not a decline in anyone else.
>
> So the real sequence runs: conviction, then action, then Yahweh honoring it, then knowledge and wisdom, then understanding of visions. The visions are the result, not the instruction. That is a different story from the one I had been carrying, and it is a better one.
>
> One more thing Daniel does not do: he never says *why* the king's food would defile him. He says that it would. The explanations available — that it was offered to idols, that it was unclean species, that it was a matter of royal patronage and dependence — are historically plausible and none of them is in the text.

ACTS 15 RECONNECTS TO NOAH, AND NOTICE WHAT IT DOES NOT SAY

The council's four prohibitions land on things sacrificed to idols, blood, what is strangled, and sexual immorality — which is territory that reaches back past Sinai toward Noah rather than being invented for the occasion.

And notice what Acts 15 does not say. It does not say Gentiles are now free of every other consideration, and it does not say Jewish believers are released from anything. It answers the question that was asked, which was about a condition of entry, and it declines to answer several that were not.

> **Acts 21, and a rumor James asks Paul to disprove**
>
> Decades after that council, Luke reports many thousands of Jewish believers in Jerusalem, all zealous for the law. And he reports a rumor circulating that Paul teaches Jews among the Gentiles to forsake Moses.

What James does with that rumor is the part I had never noticed. He does not endorse it and quietly explain it away. He asks Paul to publicly demonstrate that it is **false** — to join four men under a vow and pay their expenses, so that everyone will know there is nothing in the things they have been told about him.

And Paul does it.

I had a framework that could not comfortably hold that. So I did what I am trying to teach a reader not to do, and looked for a way around it.

The neat solution that Numbers 6:14 killed

Here is the attempt, and I am preserving it because the failure taught me more than a success would have.

The problem: if Hebrews presents Messiah's sacrifice as once for all, why is Paul in Acts 21:26 participating in Temple rites that involve offerings?

My solution was to segregate the offering types. Paul, I reasoned, participated only in a harmless completion rite — a thanksgiving or vow offering, nothing atoning. Tidy, and it preserved everything I wanted.

Then I read Numbers 6 rather than assuming it. **Numbers 6:14 includes a חַטָּאת (*ḥaṭṭāʾt*)** in the Nazirite completion, alongside the burnt, peace, grain, drink and wave offerings.

The solution was dead. And what its death exposed was worse than the original problem: **I had been flattening "sacrifice" into a single category.** Burnt, grain, peace, purification, reparation, thanksgiving and vow offerings do different things. I had been treating the word as though it named one act.

The narrowing that reopens the question is genuinely interesting and I am not going to overclaim it. The Levitical *ḥaṭṭāʾt* is often better understood as a **purification** offering — prescribed for ritual impurity, for childbirth, for bodily conditions, for purifying the sanctuary itself. Numbers 6:9 to 12 makes this vivid: a man who merely stood near a corpse owes offerings, and the text says he sinned by reason of the dead body. The modern category *sin offering means an animal dies so that*

eternal sins are forgiven is itself too crude to describe what is happening.

So participating in a rite containing a *ḥaṭṭāʾt* does **not** automatically establish that Paul sought an alternative to Messiah's redemption.

The surgical question remains open: what function did the Numbers 6 purification offering actually perform? That needs Numbers 6 worked offering by offering, before anyone decides whether Acts 21 conflicts with Hebrews — or whether the conflict is being manufactured by importing a later, flattened definition of *sacrifice* into a first-century text.

Kept under the rule this investigation set itself: a failed attempt that exposed a real error stays in the book.

ROMANS 14, AND A WORD PAIR THAT MATTERS

Romans 14 is where I expected the argument to finish, and it does not.

KOINOS AND *AKATHARTOS* IN ROMANS 14:14

κοινός · *koinos* · common, ordinary — and by extension *defiled by association or use*

ἀκάθαρτος · *akathartos* · unclean — the Levitical category proper

Romans 14:14 says nothing is *koinon* of itself. It does not say nothing is *akatharton*. Whether Paul is speaking about Levitical species categories at all, or about food rendered common by association — idol meat, table fellowship, a weak conscience — is a real question, and the word he chose does not settle it in the direction I assumed.

There is also a plain feature of Romans 14 that any reading has to account for: the disputed practice includes a believer

who **eats only vegetables**. That is not a Levitical category. No part of Torah instructs vegetarianism. Whatever dispute Paul is arbitrating, it is not straightforwardly Leviticus 11.

WHERE THIS CHAPTER ACTUALLY ENDS

Without a verdict.

I have a distinction that predates Israel and has a sacrificial function before it has a dietary one. I have a Genesis grant that complicates it. I have a Mark 7 parenthesis that is an interpretive act in every English Bible. I have a vision that Luke's own narrator interprets as being about people, and which nonetheless uses food imagery deliberately. I have an apostolic council that reaches back past Sinai. I have Paul in the Temple decades later, paying for offerings. And I have a Romans 14 that may not be about Levitical categories at all.

That is not a tidy result. It is an honest one, and the alternative available to me was to pick the two verses I started with and call it settled — which is precisely what I had been doing for years.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. The clean/unclean distinction predates Israel and begins sacrificially. Mark 7's decisive parenthesis supplies a declarative the Greek does not have, and the RVR1960 alone keeps the participial construction — without thereby settling the syntax. Peter interprets his own vision as being about people, while the vision's food imagery is not thereby emptied. Acts 15 reconnects to Noah without releasing anyone from anything it was not asked about. And a failed attempt on Acts 21 exposed that I had been treating seven kinds of offering as one word.

THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES. No verdict, and a sharper set of questions than the one I arrived with. The next institution is the one with a creation-ordinance claim attached, which none of the others had — and it is the one where a Greek word the New Testament uses exactly once will have to carry a great deal of weight.

Chapter 18: Sabbath, and the rest that remains

Of the institutions in this Part, this is the one with a claim none of the others have: it is rooted in creation before it is rooted in Sinai.

Chapter 13 noticed that in passing and deliberately set it aside. Here is where it is taken up.

TWO GROUNDS, IN TWO DIFFERENT PLACES

Exodus 20 grounds the Sabbath command in creation: six days the LORD made heaven and earth, and rested the seventh.

Deuteronomy 5 grounds the same command in the exodus: remember that you were a slave in Egypt, and the LORD your God brought you out.

Same commandment, two rationales, given by the same Torah. That is a datum rather than a contradiction, and I note it because it is the first sign that this institution is doing more than one thing at once.

And Exodus 31 adds the third: the Sabbath as a **sign** between Yahweh and the people of Israel — the covenant-sign cat-

egory Chapter 13 built, arriving exactly where that chapter said it would.

THE QUESTION THAT IS NOT THE QUESTION

The first thing that had to change was my question.

I had been asking *is Saturday still commanded?* That question has the shape of a courtroom verdict, and it invites me to sort every verse into prosecution and defence. The better question, and the one Chapter 13's machinery makes available, is: **what covenantal function does Scripture assign the Sabbath, and to whom?**

That sounds like a hedge. It is the opposite. It is the difference between a question that can be investigated and a question that can only be won.

HEBREWS 3 AND 4, READ CHRONOLOGICALLY

Hebrews takes up rest at length, and it does something with Psalm 95 worth watching: it treats the psalm as **present speech**. *Today*, if you hear his voice.

The argument runs in a sequence I had never traced. The wilderness generation failed to enter a rest. But Joshua did bring Israel into the land — so if Joshua had given them rest, the author observes, God would not speak later of another day. The psalm, written centuries after Joshua, is evidence that the rest in question was not exhausted by the conquest.

And then Hebrews reaches back farther than Joshua, to Genesis 2 and the seventh day, which is where the whole argument lands.

> **FINDING — FULFILMENT IS NOT EXHAUSTION, WITH ITS BRAKE ATTACHED**
>
> An institution can be genuinely fulfilled and still not be used up. Hebrews' own argument depends on this: the land-rest really was given, and a rest still remains.
>
> The brake, in the same breath: this may not become a device for keeping every institution permanently open. "Not exhausted" has to be shown from the text each time, as Hebrews shows it from Psalm 95's *today*, and not assumed because I would prefer the question stay open.

THEN THE VOCABULARY CHANGES AT VERSE 9

For most of the argument Hebrews uses κατάπαυσις (*katapausis*) for rest. At 4:9 it stops.

SABBATISMOS AT HEBREWS 4:9 — AND WHAT COULD NOT BE CONFIRMED

ἄρα ἀπολείπεται σαββατισμὸς τῷ λαῷ τοῦ θεοῦ — "Therefore, a *sabbatismos* remains for the people of God."

σαββατισμός (*sabbatismos*) — **not** *katapausis* again. Built from the Sabbath word-family, and deployed immediately after the author has cited Genesis's seventh-day rest. The shift is deliberate and it is real evidence.

The brake runs both ways. The word does **not** automatically prove that Hebrews commands Saturday observance. Nor may it be flattened into generic spiritual relaxation.

The translations divide along exactly that line. The ESV reads "a **Sabbath rest**," which leans toward a *state* entered. The CJB reads "a ***Shabbat*-keeping**," which leans toward an *observance* practiced. Thayer's lexicon lists both senses explicitly and declines to choose between them.

What could and could not be confirmed outside the New Testament.

Established: the word occurs **once** in the Greek New Testament, here. Thayer's lexicon cites Plutarch, *De Superstitione* c. 3, plus ecclesiastical writings, as attestation outside the New Testament.

Not confirmed: the Sabbath passage in that work of Plutarch sits at §8, not §3, and the Greek word itself was not confirmed at either place. So "*sabbatismos* is attested in Plutarch" stands as **reported by a lexicon, not independently verified.**

I am printing that gap in the body of the chapter rather than quietly citing Thayer, because this was the first time I applied a rule I had just written, and the rule immediately produced a hole instead of an answer.

> **FINDING — LEXICAL ESCALATION, AND WHAT IT COST ON ITS FIRST USE**
>
> When a word is carrying real weight in an argument, a dictionary gloss is a starting point and not a source. Go to attested primary usage.
>
> Applied here for the first time, it produced a gap rather than a confirmation — and it caught a section-number mismatch that I would otherwise have propagated. **That is the rule working, not failing.** Had I accepted the gloss, this chapter would now assert a primary-source attestation I have never checked.

WHAT THE PASSAGE DOES ESTABLISH

Strip away what I could not verify and the immediate context still gives a good deal.

Hebrews is addressing a people. It is speaking of a rest that remains, in the present tense, to people who are already believers. It grounds that rest in Genesis 2 rather than in Sinai. And it exhorts its readers to strive to enter it, which is an odd thing to say about something either wholly past or wholly future.

> ***SABBATISMOS* AFTER GENESIS 2**
>
> The vocabulary shift to *sabbatismos* at 4:9, immediately after a Genesis 2 citation, is explicit text and [SUPPORTS] reading the remaining rest as deliberately Sabbath-shaped rather than as a generic term for repose.
>
> It does **not** establish either that weekly observance is commanded here or that it is abolished here. Hebrews 4 is not addressing that question, and a passage can be highly relevant to a topic without adjudicating it.

THE PRECISE ANSWER TO THE QUESTION PEOPLE ACTUALLY ASK

So: does Hebrews 4 command weekly Sabbath keeping?

No — and the reason matters more than the answer. Hebrews 4 is not legislating practice. It is arguing that a promised rest remains open and warning against failing to enter it as the wilderness generation did. Reading it as a commandment about which day to keep imports a question the passage is not asking.

And the same discipline in reverse: Hebrews 4 does not abolish anything either. A passage that is not addressing a question cannot be used to close it from either side.

OPEN QUESTION — AND IT REOPENS THE OLDEST ONE IN THIS PART

Hebrews 4:9 says the rest remains for **the people of God**. Which raises, in the middle of a chapter about a day, the question this whole Part has been circling: who are they?

I did not expect the Sabbath chapter to hand the question forward like that. It does, and the next chapter is where it has to be faced.

COLOSSIANS, AND A PHRASE THAT CUTS IN AN UNEXPECTED DIRECTION

Colossians 2:16 and 17 tells the readers to let no one pass judgment on them in questions of food and drink, or with regard to a festival or a new moon or a Sabbath — these are a shadow of the things **to come**.

I had always heard that verse quoted as a closing argument. Reading it after Chapter 15 makes one word do something different: *things to come* is future-facing, not past-facing. Whatever else the sentence does, it is not obviously saying *these things are finished*. Hebrews 10:1 uses the same shadow vocabulary in the same forward-leaning way.

I am not resolving Colossians here. I am noting that a verse I had used as a conclusion turns out to contain a future-facing expression I had never accounted for.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. The Sabbath is grounded in creation and in the exodus and named as a covenant sign, which means it is doing more than one thing and cannot be settled by one verse. Hebrews 4 shifts deliberately into Sabbath vocabulary at the decisive moment, and the translations split on whether that means a state or an observance, with the standard lexicon declining to choose. My attempt to verify the word outside the New Testament produced a documented gap rather than an answer, and the gap is printed here rather than smoothed over. Two rules were born: fulfilment is not exhaustion, and lexical escalation. No verdict on weekly observance, because the passage is not addressing it.

THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES. Hebrews handed the question forward in the middle of an argument about a day: the rest remains for *the people of God*. That phrase has been doing quiet work through this entire Part, and it can no longer be left undefined.

Chapter 19: who are “the people of God”? — and what are we actually trying to determine?

Hebrews handed this question forward in the middle of an argument about a day, and it has been doing quiet work through every chapter of this Part. *The people of God*. I have used the phrase myself, in this book, without defining it.

IT STARTS AS UNMISTAKABLY ISRAELITE COVENANT LANGUAGE

The phrase is not vague in its origin. *I will take you to be my people, and I will be your God* is covenant formula language, spoken to Israel, and it recurs with that referent throughout the Tanakh.

Any account that begins by treating it as a generic term for the religious has already lost the thread on the first page.

BUT ISRAEL’S ELECTION WAS NEVER AN END IN ITSELF

And the second thing is equally textual. The call of Abraham has the nations in it from the beginning — in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed. Isaiah says restoring Israel is too light a thing, and adds a light to the nations.

Torah itself already legislates the foreigner who joins: the sojourner is to be loved as oneself, and provision is made for participation. Rahab and Ruth make it concrete rather than theoretical, and Ruth says the thing outright — *your people shall be my people*.

ISAIAH 19, WHICH I DID NOT EXPECT

Then a passage that stopped me, in the same chapter whose cloud-coming judgment on Egypt did work back in Part II.

Isaiah 19:24 and 25 have Israel a third with Egypt and Assyria, and Yahweh saying *blessed be Egypt my people, and Assyria the work of my hands, and Israel my inheritance*.

Egypt. Called *my people*, by Yahweh, in Israel's own Scriptures.

I am not going to overbuild on one oracle. But any framework claiming the phrase is reserved to ethnic Israel in perpetuity has to account for that verse, and I had never once been shown it.

HOSEA, AND WHAT PAUL DOES WITH IT

Hosea takes the covenant formula and runs it backward and then forward: *not my people* becomes *my people*, and *no mercy* becomes *mercy*.

Paul quotes exactly that in Romans 9, and applies it to the calling of Gentiles. Peter does something structurally similar in 1 Peter 2, taking Israel's covenant vocabulary — chosen race, royal priesthood, holy nation — and addressing it to his readers.

> **ISRAEL'S COVENANT VOCABULARY, APPLIED TO COMMUNITIES INCLUDING GENTILES**
>
> That apostolic writers apply Israel's covenant vocabulary to communities including Gentiles is explicit text, in Romans 9, Ephesians 2 and 1 Peter 2.
>
> It SUPPORTS a real, substantial incorporation rather than a metaphor or a courtesy title.
>
> It does **not** establish that the vocabulary has been transferred away from its original referent. Transfer and inclusion are different operations, and the texts that perform the second are routinely cited as though they performed the first.

THE OLIVE TREE, WHICH SAYS THE QUIET PART OUT LOUD

Romans 11 is where the structure gets stated rather than implied. Wild branches are grafted **in**. Not: a new tree is planted. Not: the old tree is felled and replaced.

And the warning attached to the graft is longer than the promise. *Do not be arrogant toward the branches. If you are, remember it is not you who support the root, but the root that supports you.*

That is Paul anticipating a specific failure mode among Gentile readers and addressing it in advance, which suggests he thought it likely.

> **FINDING — A BETTER CATEGORY THAN "REPLACEMENT"**
>
> What the texts describe is **incorporation into an existing covenantal people**, not the substitution of one people for another.
>
> That formulation does work in both directions, which is why I trust it more than the alternatives. It denies that the church replaced Israel. It also denies that Gentile believers are second-class guests at someone else's table — Ephesians 2 says fellow citizens and members of the household, which is not guest language.

THE SHARPEST TRANSLATION DIVERGENCE IN THE PART

And then Ephesians 2:15, where my two English witnesses say materially different things.

TEXTUAL NOTE — EPHESIANS 2:15, AND WHY I AM NOT RESOLVING IT

The **ESV**: "by **abolishing the law of commandments** expressed in ordinances, that he might create in himself one new man in place of the two."

The **CJB**: "by destroying in his own body the **enmity occasioned by** the *Torah*, with its commands set forth in the form of ordinances."

Those are not the same claim. One has Messiah abolishing **the law**. The other has Him destroying **the hostility attached to it**.

Interest runs both ways and settles nothing: the CJB is a Messianic Jewish translation with a stake in the narrower reading, the ESV a traditional Christian translation with a stake in the broader one.

What can be said now is contextual rather than lexical: verse 14 has just named *the dividing wall of hostility* as the thing broken down, and verse 16 speaks of reconciliation *killing the hostility*. Hostility is the paragraph's recurring object. That favours the narrower reading without demonstrating it.

This needs Greek work I have not done, so it stays open. It is the third passage in this investigation where an English rendering has been quoted to me as though it were the verse — after Mark 7:19's parenthesis and Hebrews 4:9's *sabbatismos*.

THE BRAKE, AT FULL STRENGTH

Whatever else is concluded, Romans 11 forecloses one option explicitly.

> As regards election, they are beloved for the sake of their forefathers … For the gifts and the calling of God are irrevocable (Romans 11:28-29)

That is a very strong brake against simplistic replacement. Ethnic Israel did not stop mattering to Paul, and a reading that needs it to have stopped mattering is arguing with him rather than from him.

All Israel will be saved at 11:26 I am leaving open. πᾶς Ἰσραήλ (*pas Israēl*) is among the most disputed phrases in the letter, and the candidates — ethnic Israel, the elect within Israel, the whole covenant people including Gentiles, a future restoration — are not settled by theological instinct, including mine.

AND NOW THE SECOND QUESTION IN THE TITLE

This is the part of the chapter that is about me rather than about the texts, and it is where Part III actually ends.

At this point in the investigation I stopped and asked what I was trying to determine. Not because the branches were going badly — because they were going *well*, and the richness of them had started to obscure why any of it was opened.

The original question was never about the millennium. It was this:

> Does Scripture teach that every believer living now carries a personal obligation to evangelize the whole earth, because passages such as Matthew 24:14 or the commissions require that of them?

That is a question about obligation. Everything else — the Olivet Discourse, the covenants, the clean and the unclean,

the Sabbath — arrived because answering it honestly required knowing what the texts around it actually say.

> **FINDING — THE HYPOTHESIS MUST STAY DOWNSTREAM OF THE EVIDENCE**
>
> Preterism entered this investigation as a **hypothesis being tested**, and it has to stay there.
>
> The book must never be structured as: *I am a preterist, therefore here is how Scripture proves preterism.* If it is, then the little season becomes the lens through which every preceding verse is read, and the conclusion writes the evidence.
>
> The order runs the other way. **The preceding texts must earn the hypothesis.** If they do not, the hypothesis does not survive, and several chapters from here it comes under sustained attack for exactly that reason.

The same discipline applies to my own preferred vocabulary. *Messianic Israelite* is a label I find useful. It is not Scripture's word, and Paul's language outranks it: grafted in, brought near, Abraham's offspring according to promise, fellow citizens, members of the household, one body, people of God.

Text, then synthesis, then label. Not label, then text.

WHAT KEEPS HAPPENING, NAMED

One more thing, which is the pattern this whole Part has been producing without my naming it.

I kept arriving at answers that were neither of the two options I had been offered. Not *the law is abolished* and not *nothing changed*. Not *Israel was replaced* and not *Gentiles are visitors*. Not *the Sabbath is binding* and not *the Sabbath is void*.

For a while I described that as finding a hybrid, or splitting the difference. That description was wrong, and correcting it matters.

> **FINDING — DISTINCTION WITHOUT UNNECESSARY SEPARATION**
>
> The pattern is not compromise between competing camps. It is that **Scripture repeatedly refuses the binary categories I keep trying to force onto it** — and the refusal is consistent enough to be a feature of the texts rather than a failure of my nerve.
>
> Covenant is not commandment is not sign. Fulfilment is not abolition. Inclusion is not transfer. Each of those is a distinction I did not have when this Part began, and none of them is a halfway position between two things I already believed.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. *People of God* begins as Israelite covenant language and is never merely that; Torah admits the foreigner, Isaiah calls Egypt *my people*, and the apostles apply Israel's vocabulary to communities including Gentiles. The structure is incorporation into an existing people, not substitution — and Romans 11:29 forecloses the replacement reading in Paul's own words. Ephesians 2:15 is left open pending Greek work, because two translations make materially different claims about what was abolished. And the investigation has been recentered on the question that started it, with preterism held explicitly downstream of the evidence rather than assumed above it.

THE GROWING CHAIN — CHECKPOINT 2

Fulfilment is not abolition, and the covenant story did not change owners.

THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES. The covenant question has an answer I can defend, and it is not the one either side of my original argument was offering. Which means the original question can finally be put back on the table in its own terms: Israel, the nations, and what the commission actually required of whom.